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The Sourdough Starter Rescue Kit

Is it ready? Is it dead? Is that liquid OK? Four pages that answer the questions every new sourdough baker asks in week one.



Inside: make a starter day by day · is my starter ready? checklist · normal or not? (hooch, smells, mould) · starter troubleshooting chart.

From the full **Sourdough Baking Log & Starter Guide**: loaf troubleshooting chart, baker's % cheat sheet, bulk temperature chart, schedules and 2-page bake logs.

Get the full baking log

STARTER

Make a starter: day by day

Most new starters take 7-14 days. The one moment beginners give up is days 4-6. Read that row twice.

Day 1 Mix 50 g whole wheat or rye flour + 50 g lukewarm water in a clean jar. Cover loosely. Leave somewhere warm (75-80F / 24-27C).

Day 2 You may see a few bubbles, or nothing. Keep 50 g, discard the rest, feed 50 g flour + 50 g water.

Day 3 Often a big, exciting rise. It's bacteria, not yeast yet. Keep 50 g, feed 50 g flour + 50 g water.

Days 4-6 The lull: it goes quiet or flat and may smell odd. This is normal. Do not restart. Keep feeding once a day; switch to bread or all-purpose flour with a spoon of whole grain.

Days 7-10 Activity comes back. When it rises predictably after each feed, feed twice a day (about 12 hours apart) at 1:1:1.

Ready It doubles within about 4-6 hours of a 1:1:1 feed, 2-3 days in a row, is domed and bubbly and smells pleasantly tangy. Many starters take 10-14 days, longer in a cool kitchen.

You need: a clean jar with straight sides, a rubber band, a kitchen scale, unbleached flour (start with whole wheat or rye), and filtered or dechlorinated water.

Mark the jar. Put the rubber band at the starter's level after every feed. Next time you look, you'll see exactly how much it rose.

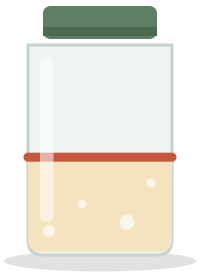
Temperature is the biggest factor. Below about 70F / 21C everything is slower: a starter can take 2-3 weeks. An oven with only the light on, or the top of the fridge, is a good warm spot.

STARTER

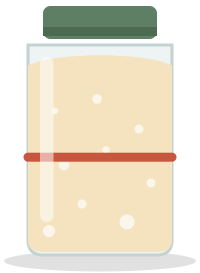
Is my starter ready?

Tick all of these before you bake your first loaf. The float test is optional: it often lies.

- [ ] It at least doubles within about 4-6 hours of a 1:1:1 feed at warm room temperature
- [ ] It does that 2-3 days in a row (one good rise isn't enough)
- [ ] The top is domed or just starting to flatten (peak), not sunken
- [ ] Bubbles all the way through when you look at the side of the jar
- [ ] Smells pleasantly sour or yogurty, not like nail-polish remover
- [ ] Texture is airy and stretchy when you lift a spoonful
- [ ] Optional: a spoonful floats in water. Wet or whole-grain starters often sink even when ready, so don't rely on it



Just fed (band)



Peak: doubled + domed

Use it at peak, or just before. If the top has sunk and there's a ring of starter on the glass above it, it's past peak. It still works, but feed it again for your best loaf.

My starter's rhythm

FEED RATIO	ROOM TEMP	HOURS TO PEAK	RISE AT PEAK	NOTES

STARTER

Normal or not?

Most things that scare new bakers are normal. Two are not.

WHAT YOU SEE	VERDICT	WHAT TO DO
Grey, brown or clear liquid on top (hooch)	Fine	It's hungry. Pour it off (milder) or stir it in (more sour), then feed. Feed more often or at a bigger ratio.
Smells of nail-polish remover, vinegar or old socks	Fine	Starved and acidic. Feed at 1:2:2 or 1:5:5 for a few feeds and the smell settles.
Dry crust on top	Fine	Scrape it off and feed from the soft starter underneath. Cover the jar a little better.
Went flat on days 4-6	Fine	The normal lull. Keep feeding on schedule. Don't restart.
Rises a little but never doubles	Needs help	Warmer spot (75-80F), unbleached flour, filtered water, feed twice a day, add 10-20% whole wheat or rye.
Very runny, rises then collapses fast	Needs help	It peaks early. Feed at a bigger ratio (1:3:3), use a little less water or more whole grain.
Pink, orange or red streaks	Throw out	Bacterial contamination. Throw the whole jar out, wash it with hot soapy water and start again.
Fuzzy mould (white, green, blue, black spots)	Throw out	Don't scrape and save it. Throw it all out. Start a new jar with a few grams of dried starter if you kept some.

Back-up tip: once your starter is healthy, smear a thin layer on parchment, let it dry fully, crumble it into a jar. Dried starter keeps for months and revives in a few days if the jar ever goes wrong.

Food safety first: when in doubt about mould or pink/orange colour, throw it out. A new starter costs a bag of flour.

FIX

Troubleshooting chart: starter

Find what you see in the left column. Change one thing, then log the next 3 feeds.

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	WHAT TO CHANGE
Bubbled on day 2-3, now flat	Normal early lull; the first rise is bacteria	Keep feeding daily. Don't restart. Expect 7-14 days.
Not rising or doubling	Too cold, bleached flour, irregular feeds, chlorinated water	Keep at 75-80F, unbleached flour, filtered water, feed twice a day, add a spoon of rye or whole wheat.
Rises, then collapses in 2-3 h	Peaking too fast (warm kitchen, small ratio)	Feed at a bigger ratio (1:3:3 or 1:5:5) or use cooler water.
Hooch on top	Hungry	Pour off or stir in, then feed more often.
Acetone or vinegar smell	Starved, too acidic	A few feeds at 1:2:2 or 1:5:5.
Float test fails	The test is unreliable for wet or whole-grain starters	Judge by doubling, dome, bubbles and smell instead.
Pink/orange streaks, fuzzy mould	Contamination	Throw it all out and start again. Not worth the risk.
Too much discard	Big starter kept on the counter	Keep 20-50 g in the fridge, feed weekly, feed 1-2 times at room temp before a bake.

Rule of thumb: a sluggish starter is almost always too cold or fed irregularly. Fix temperature and routine before you change flour.

What I tried

DATE	PROBLEM	WHAT I CHANGED	RESULT AFTER 3 FEEDS